



BEFORE

Since May 1864 the Union Army of the Potomac and the Confederate Army of Northern Virginia had been fighting each other north of the James River.

TRENCH WARFARE

Union troops assaulted Confederate forces that were firmly planted behind **cunningly contrived earthworks**. But as the soldiers settled into the Richmond-Petersburg lines, the Confederate **mastery of field fortifications was soon matched** by that of the Union armies. **Stalemate loomed**.



88,000

The estimated number of total casualties—killed, wounded, captured, and missing—incurred by both armies during the six weeks' fighting from the Battle of the Wilderness to Cold Harbor.

SUPPLY LINES

After failing to defeat Lee in open battle, Grant shifted his strategy, hoping to **sever the Confederate supply lines**—the railroads running to the south and west that kept the Army of Northern Virginia in the field.

During the siege of Vicksburg (see [The Vicksburg Campaign](#)), Grant had tightened a ring around the defending army so no supplies could get in and starved it into submission—a tactic that he would pursue again.

In June 1864, Lee remarked to his staff that if Grant managed to cross the James River and arrive before Petersburg, “it will become a siege, and then it will be a mere question of time.” By July the military situation had indeed taken on all the appearance of a siege. For 35 miles (56km), a curving line of entrenchments stretched from north of Richmond to west of Petersburg—a labyrinth of front lines, secondary lines, bombproof shelters, rifle pits, and small forts, or redoubts, scarred the flat landscape. Sharpshooters ruled this denuded world, picking off the unwary. Artillery always thundered somewhere. It was a life lived almost entirely underground. Dirt, mud, sun, rain, wind, and sky—and the occasional whizzing bullet—marked its boundaries.